

Cambridge Harkener

Celebrating the Heritage of Cambridge and Jeffersonville Vermont

Cambridge, Vermont

Vol. II, No. 1

Summer 2002

Current Officers

Co-Presidents: Clark Dodge, Roberta Marsh

Vice President: Joel Page

Secretary: Marc Mallett

Co-Secretary: Julie Twombly Brown

Treasurer: Bill Putnam

Directors:

Diancy Boyden, Adam Howard,

Georgeana Little, Bill Sander,

Jane Shaw, Linda Ward

Honorary Directors:

Harold Putnam, Wendell Wells

Society Officers Honored

The historical society was very proud indeed, when two of our valued members were honored on February 3, 2002 at the Mary & Alden Bryan Memorial Gallery, as individuals who have served our community in such a way as to make it a better place for us all.

The *5th annual Eccles Award* was given to *Clark Freeman Dodge*, our Co-president. Over the years he has served as Selectman, School Director and as a member of the Jeffersonville Cemetery Association. Clark and his wife June have an extensive collection of town artifacts and the knowledge to explain them - a resource which we utilize constantly.

The *6th annual Bridge Builders Award* was presented to *Jane George Shaw*, one of our Board

Members. Jane has been the working force behind the world of art exhibited at the Mary & Alden Bryan Memorial Gallery. She has brought together the very best of volunteers

from the community to help promote the visual and performing arts. In 1996 she worked with Town Officials and the U.S. Postal Service to turn the Town's 1826 Old Town Hall into the new home of the Jeffersonville Post Office.

Family, friends, community members, society members and volunteers turned out to celebrate the

work of these two individuals who so enrich our Cambridge community.



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Presidents' Report

It seems like just a few weeks ago that Clark and I agreed to share the presidency, and now we find ourselves wondering how the second half of the year will shape up!

We expect Fall will follow Summer and Winter should arrive soon after - these happenings seem to be a definite - but in between these seasons we hope our building will have been brought up to code for the first phase. It has been a long process.

I attended a conference in St. Johnsbury recently and was overwhelmed at the progress other societies had made, but two things are obvious - we are still a fledgling group and we are not wealthy - yet we have accomplished much in a relatively short time.

Please feel free to share your thoughts, opinions and concerns with us. After all, this is your society!

—Clark F. Dodge

—Roberta S. Marsh

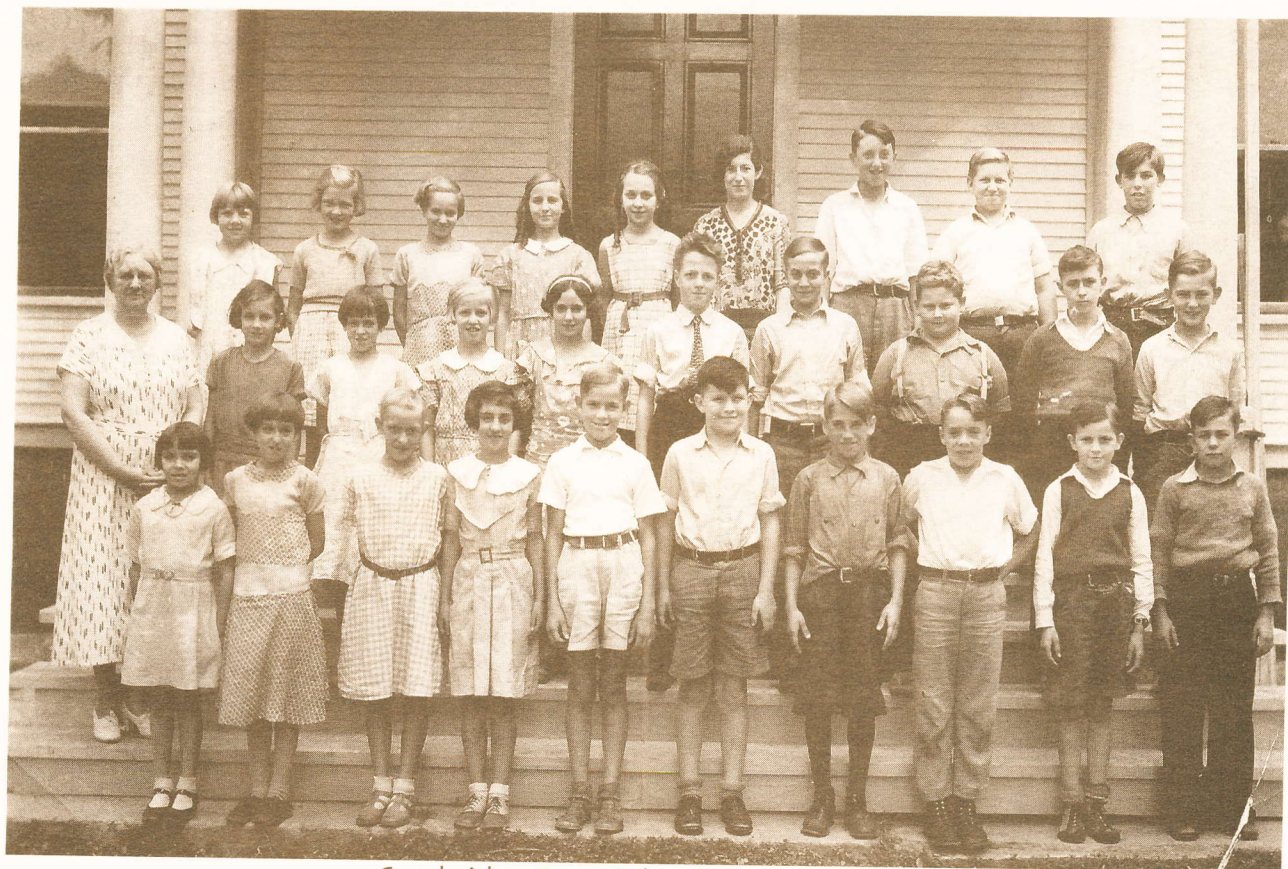
Acquisition/Collections Committee Report

The Acquisition / Collections Committee met Monday, April 15th with ten members present. Carol Bacon has done extensive research for receiving items and we discussed many of these recommendations. We reviewed the collections policy, recognized the importance of collecting Cambridge related items only, discussed the procedure for actually receiving items, how and where to store the items, etc. We all agreed a trial-run "collection workshop" would benefit us. It was proposed that duplicate items might best serve as a traveling exhibit for school or other educational purposes.

As supplies will need to be purchased, such as storage boxes, acid-free tissue, etc., we will need to find funding for this project.

Due to imminent building renovations we are, unfortunately, not ready to accept items, but we recognize the need to prepare.

—Diancy Boyden



Cambridge Boro School ☞ Circa ????

How many of these students can you name? Rex Gates was able to identify all but three!

And what about the teacher?

The Way I Remember it...the Cambridge Boro School

I remember lots of stairs...stairs to the second floor....stairs to the basement...stairs on the outside of the building in case of fire...big stairs in the front to wait for Harold Nolan's bus home. I remember Mrs. Foss and Mrs. Ellsworth. The older kids were upstairs with Miss Green. We had Miss Green in the afternoon. As we walked up the stairs to her room 5th and 6th graders, the big kids, would often tell us to be careful because Miss Green was in a bad mood. We were good. We were so good that the 4th graders got to plan lots of trips around the United States. We were so jealous! Strange that they just talked about all those great places described in their Social Studies book, but never actually went anyplace. It sure made it hard for us 3rd graders to focus on our lessons.

I remember going over to Babe and Lois Cutler's house to use their phone. We could even cut through the flower patch and go in their back door. I don't remember there ever being a telephone at school.



Mrs. Henrietta Ellsworth & Mrs. Ada Foss
looking younger than I remember

The Bookmobile visited the school and we took turns going out to the van to select our library books. The teacher's pets usually got to have this honor.

Recess was determined by the seasons and was not a liability issue. We got to go ice skating on the Foss meadow that my dad now owns. We dug big holes in the dirt all around the school to play marbles. Socks of marbles changed hands each day as we showed our skills with 'dropsies' and



'bootsies'. I remember we were allowed to walk to Booth's IGA to buy candy at lunch recess. In the 50s, we could actually purchase items with pennies.

I remember lunch with Mrs. Sweet. She had a blackboard with names of the finicky eaters on it. They were labeled the "Birds". I was so proud not to be on that list like my friend Linda Cutler. I wish now that I had been a "Bird". We had cups of

thick corn chowder, warm chocolate cake and black olives with pits. We were sure no one else in Vermont had seen those olives before. Cambridge kids had it all.

I remember our show at the Cambridge Community Hall. I can't remember the theme of each show. I know Roger St. Cyr sang "Runaway" and my brother Jeff won a twist contest. Debbie Raymond got the good parts. Boys who were troublemakers played the sticks during their class performance. It seems that we raised money to buy a record player for the school and square dance albums. Remember the Cambridge Cardinals?

The end of the year picnic was so much fun. Sometimes we went roller skating at Malletts Bay. Sometimes we had scavenger hunts in Mrs. Foss' woods; 25 points for a frog. We got to ride our bikes to school too. Imagine all the "Valley Kids" riding their bikes down that road now. We got to pack our own lunches...bottles of pop, oreo cookies and potato chip sandwiches. Things couldn't have been any better.

I know Mrs. Kittle and Mrs. Davis worked there too. Ralph Lewis cut his head really badly doing an undercut with the wooden swings. Arlan Smith got a knuckle wrap with a ruler.

He may have lost his chance to go on a Social Studies trip with his class. School was closed because we all had lice. Mark Gates was really smart and could draw things about space. Denis Guilmotte could do any modern math. We all knew about Dick, Jane and Sally.

This is the way I remember Cambridge Boro school. How about you?



Remember the
Author?

Cooking on a wood stove evinces images of frontier women in long gingham dresses slowly stirring a stew atop their stove. Actually, today in Cambridge, wood stoves are still being used on a daily basis for cooking and baking. One resident who uses a wood stove is June Dodge, wife of our Co-President Clark. Her Victor Countess model cast iron range and stove occupies center stage in her small kitchen.

The stove consists of a fire box on the left, into which the wood is loaded, and a fairly large oven on the right. The oven door opens to the right, so that it is out of the way while tending to the contents. June remembers her mother's stove door opening down, and constantly being in the way. The top of the stove, what would be called today the range, has several circular griddles located across it's surface which can be removed with a lid lifter to observe the "workings". In addition, there are movable trivets on either side of the range, which can swivel backwards to be out of the way or forwards over the range to be used for keeping things such as a coffee or tea pot warm. There are also two dampers, one on either side of the range, one to control air to the oven and the other to the firebox. Finally, there is a flue control in the pipe leading from the oven to the chimney. These dampers, the pipe flue and the amount of wood are the only controls determining the temperature of the oven and range.

The most common woods used for cooking are maple, birch, ash and black cherry. These last two are prized because they split easily, not a small consideration when you remember how much wood is needed daily. The fire is started with small pieces of kindling wood and newspapers and then the larger pieces of wood are added. Smaller pieces are preferable when baking to heat up the oven quickly and keep it up to temperature throughout the baking process. For a slow fire, however, larger pieces are used. Once the fire is started, it takes only about 15 minutes for the range to be ready to cook. When baking, the "oven damper" is opened to allow the fire to flow over the top of the oven chamber. Otherwise, this damper is kept closed. June's oven has a temperature gauge, a modern convenience, but older models had none. Temperature would be determined by holding one's

hand in the oven ("Ouch, I guess it's ready!") or using some flour in a pie pan or a feather and determining the temperature by how long it took them to brown. This is where the art comes in. Temperature is controlled by opening and closing the damper and/or the flue on the pipe and by the amount and size of wood fed into the firebox. June also remembers her mother adding potato peelings or salt to the firebox when the stovepipe began to overheat, to cool down the fire quickly and avoid catastrophe.

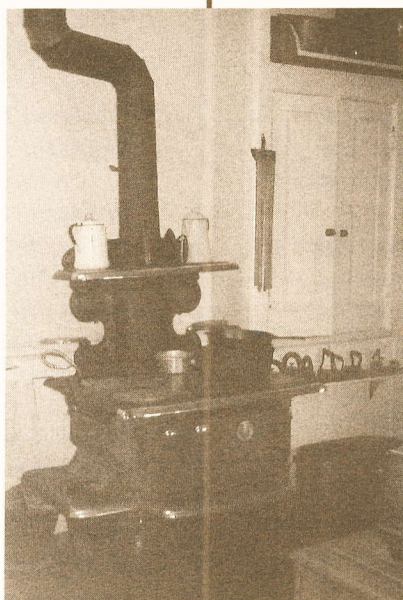
Cooking on top of the stove is a slow process. Cast iron skillets and casseroles are best for wood stove cooking since, like the stove itself, they distribute the temperature evenly and hold their

heat. Clark cooks his morning toast on the top of the stove using a wire toaster to hold the bread. Although not encouraged, individual potato slices can be cooked directly on the cook top as a treat (providing the person who has to clean the stove is out of the room). Hotdogs or other greasy foods, however, should never be cooked directly on the cook top. Unlike an outdoor grill, the grease doesn't drop away from the food, but collects and burns and makes an unholy mess.

Oven baking is somewhat time consuming. Although the actual cooking time may not be much longer than in a modern gas or electric oven, the contents need constant attention. Since the fire is concentrated on one side of the oven, near the firebox, and the top of the oven is also being heated, but

the bottom isn't, it is necessary to move your bread or cookies or whatever from one side of the oven to the other, from top to bottom and from back to front on a continuing basis — no setting a timer and returning in an hour when the bread is done. Once again, one is reminded that cooking on a wood stove is an art.

There is probably as much time spent in cleaning a wood stove as in cooking on it. The top of the stove needs to be cleaned before, during and after use. In addition, every week or two the top should be "blackened" using a prepared paste or liquid which polishes and protects the cast iron. In the past, a homemade concoction would have been used, but today there are commercial products available. The cleanliness, the shine, of a



The Victor Countess

woman's stove would have been one measure of her worth. (Thank God some things change.)

The oven almost cleans itself. Like a modern self-cleaning oven, the oven of a wood stove reaches such high temperatures that dirt and cooking residue simply burn off and fall to the floor of the oven as ashes, where they can be dusted out. No art involved here.

Of course, the ashes have to be removed from the firebox on a regular basis. They are scraped out with an ash scraper and transferred to an ash bucket (such imaginative names) until they can be safely disposed of outside (more on this later). Since live embers are likely to be hidden under the ash, it is imperative that the ashes be disposed of carefully. At least some of the fires in Cambridge's past were probably due to unsafe disposal of the ashes from a wood burning stove.

The messiest, most unpleasant part of wood stove cooking is cleaning out the stove pipe. This is also one of the most important parts. A dirty stovepipe invites chimney fires and then, poof! another Cambridge house enters history, permanently. It doesn't take much imagination to realize why this chore is so unpopular. Remove the stovepipe and ash flies everywhere. Yuck!

The wood stove was not used exclusively for cooking. Often, there was a large water reservoir attached to the side or back of the stove. Keep the reservoir full, and hot water was available whenever needed. The water could be used for washing dishes or clothes...or people. Many Saturday night baths would have taken place in the kitchen near the stove which had heated the hot water.

The stove would also, obviously, be a great source of heat in the winter. Since you had to have the stove going anyway, you could save on the other heating sources (fireplaces, Franklin stoves, furnaces). Unfortunately, they would also be a great source of heat in the summer, when it would have been much less welcome. Often, farmhouses would have separate "summer" kitchens away from the main living areas or would use kerosene burning ovens which give off less heat. June remembers that these kerosene ovens needed to be watched carefully since if they got too hot they would give off a nasty black "gunk" that would cover everything in the kitchen. Apparently once, her grandmother left her grandfather in charge of watching the kerosene oven while she popped over to see a neighbor. He, being a man, got absorbed in his own work and forgot about the fire. When he finally remembered, it was too late. The kitchen was a mess. His attempts to cover his

"crime" only made things worse - by trying to scrub the black goo off the walls he only managed to smear it around. Needless to say, grandmother was unamused when she returned.

Nothing was (or is) wasted. The ashes from the stove would be collected and stored, and when there was a sufficient quantity they would be used to make lye, a principle ingredient of soap. Water would be added to the compressed ashes and allowed to leach through the ashes. The final product of this process was the lye. The lye would then be combined with fat (beef or pig) and heated until it reached the consistency of watery mayonnaise. It would then be poured into molds and allowed to harden. Before the mixture had hardened completely, it would be cut into the convenient bar shapes that we would recognize as soap. Apparently, the strength of this soap was legendary as being almost flesh-eating. Still, an apparent waste product was recycled into a necessary resource. June doesn't make soap with her ashes, but they are taken out and spread on the garden as a fertilizer. In winter, they are buried under the snow to fertilize the ground for spring and to minimize any fire threat.

There can be no better ending to this story about the art of wood stove cooking than June Dodge's own words:

"People who think using a wood stove is fun and romantic, probably haven't ever had to use one. Talk to someone who has and you'll get the 'rest of the story'."

—Geana Little



June in her pantry — ready to "cook"

Medicine . . . The Way it Used to Be

Some eighty years ago, there was an event in Cambridge that, no doubt, few people today know about. I was around ten years old and needed to

have my tonsils and adenoids removed, as did about 8-10 other children. Among them were Chauncy Perry and his sister, as well as Lorraine Dodge, who unbeknown to me at that young age, would become my wife in later years.

A surgeon came up from Burlington to the Cambridge High School for the clinic. Tables were removed from the Home Economics Room on the first floor, covered with sheets

and placed in the 1st & 2nd grade room, also on the first floor, down the hall. It was here that ether was administered. We were carried back to the Home Economics Room where the surgery was performed and then taken back to allow us sufficient time to wake up before our parents could take us home.

The Minister in town, a Mr. Bartlett, visited each home that evening to check up on us. I do remember Chauncy Perry had some post-op bleeding, because he didn't follow the instructions - only liquids and a soft diet.

—Stub Wells

I was 16 years old when it was advised that I had to have my tonsils and adenoids removed. My father wanted to have this done at the hospital in Burlington. My mother, however, did talk him into allowing it to be done in the clinic at the school.

Although several years later, the procedure was about the same as Stub described. There were also about 8-10 children involved, but the big difference was that we stayed overnight at the school. I remember being carried to the operating table by Fabyan Jacques, who was helping out.

I did have some post-op bleeding and had to have a compress dressing in my throat attached to a string, to help stop the bleeding. My most pleasant memory is of my grandpa Hapgood bringing me ice cream when I got home. It tasted soooo good.

—Tillie Warren



Announcements and Coming Events

June 12—Monthly Meeting

A Tribute to Stub Wells on the occasion of his 90th birthday

June 22 & 23—Vermont History Expo, Tunbridge

A two day event featuring exhibits, lectures, demonstrations and more

July 4—Parade and Fundraiser

FLOAT

CHS will have a float in the annual Independence Day parade. If you would like to help on the float call Clark Dodge (644-2942).

TAG SALE

Warner Lodge Building

Please consider donating items for the sale. For information on when and where to bring donations, contact Roberta Marsh (644-2678). She'd also be interested in hearing from anyone who would like to help before, during and after the event.

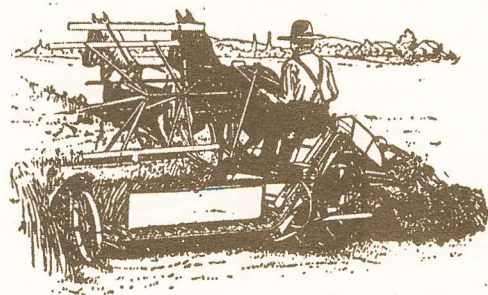
PITCH IN!

July 10—Monthly Meeting

Cambridge Junction and the Railroad
A presentation by rail expert Jerry Fox

Coming in the Fall—Old Farm Days

An exhibition and demonstration of farm equipment and household conveniences from the "Good Old Days".



Annual Meeting of Vermont Historical Societies

On May 4, nearly 100 local Historical Societies sent members to a day-long gathering in St. Johnsbury, which included a keynote speaker and workshops followed by tours of the city and viewing of its architecture and the art collection of its renowned Athenaeum.

Three members of our Society heard a descendant of the Flanders family describe her grandmother Flanders' years collecting the words and music from over 4,000 New England songs (What songs do you recall from family memories?) These are actual recordings of voices of men and women who still knew the songs from earlier times. The collection is preserved in the Library of Congress in Washington D C.

Over a buffet lunch there was time to network with members from other societies, look at newsletters, family and town histories, and much information of interest to societies on all aspects of good museum procedures.

Afternoon workshops were offered on collection policy, care and preservation of collections and the buildings that house them, postcard collections, community outreach, school and museum projects and more. The workshop leaders were experts in their fields and included our own Doug Porter, leading the workshop on preserving old buildings.

Of particular interest to our members was the awards event, which recognized outstanding members who had done much for their particular societies in research, building improvement, innovative public relations, etc. The newsletters honored were good, leading us to think about nominating our "Harkener" next time for its very real quality and spirit.

At \$15.00, which includes lunch, this is a great bargain. More members should consider attending next year.

—Carol Bacon



The March Potluck Dinner was enjoyed by all

A Flatlander wants to know.....about Planting

If possible, I know even less about the plant side of farming than I do about the cow side. I've seen the fields sprout crops in the summer and I've watched as these crops are harvested in the fall, but what they are, how they're planted and what happens to them after harvesting was a mystery. Therefore, I decided to seek out a competent source to remedy, at least partially, my stupidity. I was directed to Clark Dodge, who proved to be quite patient with my stupid questions. [Author's note: Any mistakes or misstatements in what follows should not be attributed to the source, but to the author!]

My first question was what exactly is planted. I can recognize corn when I see it and I knew that that was the crop most commonly seen in the fields of Lamoille County. The corn is planted in late May and harvested in late September or early October. The husk and cob are then ground into a meal to be used as fodder (notice the farming terminology I'm picking up!). That's what's in the silos! Sometimes the fields are planted in the fall with winter rye or wheat. Now, I don't remember anything growing in the fields over the winter, except snow drifts. Apparently, these winter crops lie dormant over the winter and are plowed under in the spring as they begin to sprout and help to fertilize the fields.

I've noticed large bundles in many fields that appear to be covered with plastic. Some of these bundles are cylindrical (marshmallows, Clark calls them) and some are long, like worms. I was told that these contain haylege, a form of hay that is not fully dried. Now come the really stupid questions. Clark was very patient, although he did laugh out loud once. What is hay? Hay is dried grasses. Okay. What is grass? Now that sounds stupid, but I knew it wasn't the kind I have on my lawn. Now I know. Grass, in this sense, is a combination of clover of different varieties, alfalfa and even some Kentucky bluegrass. Now how many of you really knew that? You need a flatlander around to ask the stupid questions.

I learned a lot of other things while talking to Clark - more than I can fit in this short article. Things like

Oats are raised to feed to the horses

Carrots can be left in the ground over the winter

Heifers are females before the age of milking, which begins after about 1 1/2-2 years.

I know this last isn't about planting, but I had to ask.

—Geana Little

Volunteers Wanted!

The July 4th Tag Sale is in need of donations of saleable objects. As you do your spring cleaning start putting aside things you wish to donate to the sale. For additional information about where and when to bring your donations contact Roberta Marsh at 644-2678. Anyone who can spare some time to take in objects and tag them or to sell on the 4th, should also contact Roberta.

If your interest runs more towards floats, Clark would love some help preparing and manning our float for the parade. Give him a call at 644-2942 to offer your services. Let's grab an award this year!

The photo on the cover, of Clark Dodge and Jane Shaw, as well as the picture of the Potluck Dinner were taken by Hugh List. We appreciate his expertise in providing these photographs. We hope to have more of his work in future additions.

Meetings are held the 2nd Wednesday of the month at 7:00 pm
Warner Lodge Building, School Street, Jeffersonville.
We hope to see you at the next meeting.



Cambridge Historical Society
Warner Lodge Building
School Street
Jeffersonville, VT 05464